



Refugees in Beirut. President Trump has tried to press Europe for help, but leaders there are wary of being pulled further into war.

A Presidency Characterized By ‘Epic Fury’

By PETER BAKER

WASHINGTON — By his own account, President Trump was asked to personally pick the name of the military operation against Iran and was bored by all the choices presented to him. “They gave me, like, 20 names, and I’m like, falling asleep,” he said last week. “I didn’t like any of them.”

Then at last he was offered another option: Operation Epic Fury. That woke him up. “I like that name,” he told supporters at a rally in Kentucky. “I like that name.” And so it was selected.

After all, Epic Fury captures the Trump presidency in its essence. Everything Mr. Trump does, at least as he sees it, is epic — the biggest, the most, the first, “like we’ve never seen before,” as he likes to say. And much of what he does seems to be driven by fury, a deep and abiding enmity toward the forces arrayed against him or those he blames for what he considers the downfall of the country under other presidents.

Operation Epic Fury, therefore, is a quintessentially Trumpian choice for the name of a war. Not for him an Operation Just Cause (Panama), Operation Restore Hope (Somalia), Operation Uphold Democracy (Haiti) or Operation Enduring Freedom (Afghanistan). While other military operation names in modern times have evoked broader American values or uplifting sentiments like freedom and hope, Mr. Trump prefers rage.

This is in a way the Anger Presidency. Anger defines Mr. Trump’s decade on the political stage. Anger at foreigners who come to this country and change its nature. Anger at allies who take advantage of America. Anger at Democrats who cross him. Anger at Republicans who cross him. Anger at appointees he deems insufficiently loyal. Anger at prosecutors, F.B.I. agents, judges, journalists, law firms, elite universities, cultural figures, corporate leaders, pollsters, central bankers and the Norwegian Nobel Committee.

His rally speeches, news conferences and social media feed are suffused with anger. In the past week, he attacked the “truly sick and demented people” in the

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Swirl of Intrigue Elevated a New Leader of Iran

By FARNAZ FASSIHI

Mojtaba Khamenei’s ascension as Iran’s new supreme leader might have appeared straightforward, even predestined. In fact, it was neither.

His rise came only after a full-on war of succession. The high-stakes process became the Islamic Republic’s version of “Game of Thrones”: an empty throne; a council of clerics; and two dynasties — Khamenei and Khomeini — competing. Political figures vied, military commanders defended their realms, and a former spy master known for plotting assassinations weighed in.

Even in the best of times, the task of finding Iran’s third Su-

Killing of the Ayatollah Steered Clerics in an Unlikely Direction

preme Leader — the man who would not only represent God on earth, but wield authority over politics and the armed forces — would have been challenging. Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, after all, had ruled since 1989, through decades of tumult in the country.

But during a war with the United States and Israel, as bombs dropped from the sky and explosions rocked the earth, the selection of a successor with a lifetime appointment became a full-

on test of whether the theocracy could survive.

This recounting of the inner deliberations, power plays and rivalries that thrust the ayatollah’s reclusive 56-year-old son into the leadership role is based on interviews with five senior Iranian officials, two clerics, two Iranians affiliated with the supreme leader’s office and three members of the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps with knowledge of the selection process. They all asked for anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly about internal government deliberations.

By all accounts, Mr. Khamenei most likely would not have risen if his father had died a natural

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One Oscar After Another
Jessie Buckley (“Hamnet”) and Michael B. Jordan (“Sinners”) won for best actress and actor, while the “One Battle After Another” director Paul Thomas Anderson earned multiple awards. Page C1.

Mamdani Flashes Smile in Public, and Wields Sharp Elbows as Political Operator

By NICHOLAS FANDOS and SALLY GOLDENBERG

Zohran Mamdani was on the brink of completing his buoyant ascent to City Hall last November when he stepped off the campaign trail to take care of a less savory matter.

He had gotten wind that a fellow young leftist, Councilman Chi

Ossé of Brooklyn, was gearing up to challenge Representative Hakeem Jeffries, the House Democratic leader. The councilman, inspired by Mr. Mamdani’s insurgent campaign, might have expected to have his support.

But when Mr. Mamdani phoned Mr. Ossé on the eve of Election Day, the mayor-to-be was furious. He told the councilman that he

could not win, and that if he started a high-profile fight, it would undermine the left. Then the hardball started.

First, Mr. Mamdani told Mr. Ossé he would like to make him a key figure in his governing coalition — imagining the councilman at his side, for example, when he announced a new bus lane in his district — but only if he dropped

Judge Rejects Kennedy’s Limits For Child and Covid Vaccines

By APOORVA MANDAVILLI

In a severe blow to the Trump administration’s health agenda, a federal judge in Massachusetts on Monday blocked the government from implementing a series of decisions on vaccines made over the last year by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.

The ruling also reversed, at least for the time being, all decisions made by the panelists that Mr. Kennedy appointed to the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices, which makes recommendations on which vaccines Americans should take. The court decision will prevent the committee from meeting later this week, as it was scheduled to do.

The judge’s ruling abruptly halted the major changes set in motion by Mr. Kennedy, who has long been skeptical of vaccines. The secretary had upended national vaccine policy and made sweeping revisions to the recom-

mendations for what shots are given and when. Those included cutting down the number of diseases covered by routine immunization and restricting access to Covid vaccines, two pillars of Mr. Kennedy’s vaccine agenda.

In his decision, Judge Brian Murphy, of the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts, noted that the vaccine committee has historically made decisions through careful review of scientific evidence, “a method scientific in nature and codified into law through procedural requirements.” But, he added, “unfortunately, the government has disregarded those methods and thereby undermined the integrity of its actions.”

The ruling by Judge Murphy, who was appointed to the federal bench by President Joseph Biden, a Democrat, will almost certainly

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Russia’s ‘Unhealthy’ Obsession
A cuddly, gentle cartoon character’s wild popularity in Russia troubles some conservatives there. *PAGE A4*

Region’s Support for Cuba Sags
Latin America’s left once saw Cuba as its lodestar. Now leaders across the spectrum are more wary. *PAGE A9*

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An Art School Trump Likes
National Endowment for the Humanities awards are flowing to handpicked projects, including millions to an institution with three employees. *PAGE A15*

A Chef’s Fall Reverberates
In the industry where Noma’s René Redzepi reigned, his fellow chefs are debating how, and how much, restaurant kitchens can change. *PAGE A11*

A Lever of Power for Epstein
The disgraced financier used his money and influence in the world of elite private schools to assist friends and acquaintances. *PAGE A17*



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An Early Rocketeer
Long before that step on the moon, Robert Goddard tested a liquid-fueled projectile on his aunt’s farm. *PAGE D1*

When the Clue Is Underfoot
A group of scientists and law enforcement officials is pointing to the role moss can play in crime solving. *PAGE D1*

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A Big Home Insurance Factor
Credit history has such a stronghold on securing home insurance rates across the country that owners of identical homes can pay wildly different rates to insure them. *PAGE B7*

Struggles at Lululemon
A corporate feud has destabilized a yoga pants empire, with interim chief executives trying to rejuvenate sales as the founder engages in a proxy battle for the boardroom. *PAGE B1*

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SPORTS B8-12

N.C.A.A. Tournament Time
Azzi Fudd, above, will be a key player for the top-seeded Connecticut women. On the men’s side, Duke is the No. 1 overall seed. *PAGE B8*

